

The Congress is struggling to counter the BJP's assertion that it is becoming not just a regional party, but increasingly one dominated by Muslim representation

TIME TO INTROSPECT Rahul Gandhi, Mallikarjun Kharge and K.C. Venugopal at the Congress Working Committee meeting, New Delhi, Apr. 10

Kerala provided the lone bright spot. Along with its partners in the United Democratic Front (UDF), the Congress secured an impressive 102 of the 140 seats. Yet even that victory underlined a larger reality: the Congress now draws most of its governing strength from the South. It rules on its own in three of the five southern states—Karnataka, Telangana and, now, Kerala—and remains a junior ally in Tamil Nadu. In the North, it governs only Himachal Pradesh and has a foothold in Jharkhand as part of the Jharkhand Mukti Morcha-led *mahagathbandhan*.

Overall, the Congress is struggling to counter the BJP's assertion that it is becoming not just a regional party, but increasingly one dominated by Muslim representation. In Assam, 18 of its 19 MLAs are Muslims, all elected from Muslim-majority seats. In Bengal, both its winners are Muslims from Murshidabad. In Kerala, of the UDF's 102 MLAs, 30 are Muslims and 29 Christians, a composition the BJP is already framing as "minority rule" to prise Hindus away from the secular bloc. In Tamil Nadu, the Congress's five MLAs include three Christians, one Muslim and one Dalit, with no upper-caste Hindu representation. The Congress disputes this reading, pointing out that 78 per cent of its 664 MLAs across India are Hindus and only 12 per cent Muslims.

The Perception Problem

The perception, however, cuts deeper. The Congress itself acknowledged this after its 2014 Lok Sabha defeat, when the A.K. Antony committee identified the party's "pro-Muslim" image as a major problem. The charge, of course, was not new; versions of it had long been advanced by the Sangh Parivar, dating back to the days of Jawaharlal Nehru. What changed after 2014, says political scientist Rahul Verma, was its electoral potency. As the BJP increasingly turned state elections into bipolar contests, the Muslim vote—once considered a tactical advantage in fragmented coalition politics—began to carry a political cost for the Congress, driving Hindu consolidation around a perception cultivated over two decades.

The pattern is visible in the five states with the highest Muslim population shares: Assam, West Bengal, Kerala, Uttar Pradesh and Bihar. The Congress is in power only in Kerala; the BJP or its allies govern the other four. Kerala could become the BJP's next laboratory, with the party's gradual organisational expansion beginning to resemble its earlier groundwork in Assam and Bengal. The recent tussle over Kerala's chief ministership may deepen that perception. Congress insiders say the high command favoured K. C. Venugopal, the AICC general secretary for organisation, but the Indian Union Muslim League used its leverage to block the move, signalling that if Venugopal were anointed CM, it could be less supportive in future elections, including for Rahul or Priyanka Gandhi in Wayanad.

Yashwant Deshmukh, founder-director of the polling agency C-Voter, says the episode reflects how dependent the Congress in Kerala has become on a Muslim ally, to the point where even routine personnel decisions are constrained. That dependence, he argues, may deepen as the BJP attempts to push Kerala towards its own "Bengal moment". Political analyst Yogendra Yadav rejects that interpretation. "It is a classic case of spin doctoring to suggest that the BJP is gaining because minorities are consolidating around the Congress or other Opposition parties. The cause-and-effect relationship works the other way around," he says. "The BJP's relentless assault on minorities, especially Muslims, leaves them with no option but to back non-BJP parties. This is exactly what the BJP